

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1987-06-28

dear bahá'í friends,

your letter of 25 may 1987 concerning mr. . . . has been received by the universal house of justice, which has directed us to reply as follows.

in considering the status of believers such as mr. . . . , it is necessary to review the requirements for membership in the bahá'í community. The basic considerations are set out by the guardian in his statement:

. . . i would only venture to state very briefly and as adequately as

present circumstances permit the principal factors that must be taken into consideration before deciding whether a person may be regarded a true believer or not. full recognition of the station of the forerunner,

the Author, and the True exemplar of the bahá'í cause, as set forth

in 'Abdu'l-bahá's Testament; unreserved acceptance of, and submission to, whatsoever has been revealed by their pen; loyal and steadfast

adherence to every clause of our beloved's sacred will; and close as-

sociation with the spirit as well as the form of the present day bahá'í

administration throughout the world—these i conceive to be the fun-

damental and primary considerations that must be fairly, discreetly and thoughtfully ascertained before reaching such a vital decision. . . .

(Bahá'í Administration, p. 90, october 2, 1925)^{32.1}

32.2

32.2a

message from The universal house of justice

ing the issue of acceptance of new believers, when it wrote:

Those who declare themselves as bahá'ís should become en-

chanted with the beauty of the teachings, and touched by the love

of bahá'u'lláh. The declarants need not know all the proofs, history,

laws, and principles of the faith, but in the process of declaring them-

selves they must, in addition to catching the spark of faith, become basically informed about the central figures of the faith, as well as

the existence of laws they must follow and an administration they

must obey.

(from a letter to all National Spiritual Assemblies, 1 j uly 196)32-1

it follows that individuals who do not satisfy these requirements cannot be regarded as members of the bahá'í community, irrespective of whatever statements they might make concerning the nature of their belief in bahá'u'lláh. Such a situation arises, in some instances, when a person claims to accept the station of bahá'u'lláh but does not accept the authority of the Administrative institutions. The guardian clarified this matter in a letter written on his behalf, stating:

. . . To accept the cause without the administration is like to accept the teachings without acknowledging the divine station of bahá'u'lláh.

To be a bahá'í is to accept the cause in its entirety. To take exception to one basic principle is to deny the authority and sovereignty of bahá'u'lláh, and therefore is to deny the cause. . . .

(letter to a National Spiritual Assembly, 0 m ay 190)

if you feel that mr. . . . does not accept "the authority and sovereignty of bahá'u'lláh" as explained above, despite the statements he might make asserting his acceptance of the bahá'í faith, you should remove his name from the list of members and regard him as being a non-b ahá'í.

if you feel that the continued association of the bahá'ís with mr. . . . is potentially damaging to their belief or is detrimental to the unity of the community, you could well consider advising the believers to avoid association with him.

32-1. See muhj, no. 18.32.2b

32.3

32.3a

32.4

32.5

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6The house of justice advises you to deal with this matter in a straightforward way, avoiding any actions which might serve to increase mr. . . .'s sense of his own importance or which might needlessly antagonize him and hence provoke him into active opposition of the i nstitutions.

The house of justice will offer its prayers at the Sacred Threshold for
your guidance in resolving this matter.

with loving bahá'í greetings,

Department of the secretariat

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Functioning of an Executive Committee
of a National Spiritual Assembly

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]